

WAITING FOR RAIN A farmer at his fast-drying paddy field in Bandipora district in Kashmir, Jul. 2

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Takeaways

- **Kashmir withers under a prolonged dry spell, with temperatures breaching 50- and 70-year records**
- **Rainfall deficits in the range of 75% in Jun-Jul**
- **11% of Kashmir's 132,000 ha. of paddy fields are dry**
- **Blueprint: dams, tanks, eventual shift to other crops**

JAMMU AND KASHMIR

DRY RUN FOR A FUTURE FAMINE

Never-before scenes of shrivelled paddy in south Kashmir raise fears over long-term food security

By **Kaleem Geelani**

THE GREEN RICE PADDIES that dot NH-44 in Anantnag, on the southern edges of Kashmir, are counting their last days. It's peak farming season, but Mohammad Shafi Malik's 30-kanal farm in Jablipora, Bijbehara, has cracked and parched soil with shrivelled paddy saplings, depressing proof of the water crisis in this Himalayan region, one of the worst in its history. "The lands are without water for almost a month. This is the end of our paddy crop," the 54-year-old tells INDIA TODAY, standing at a point on the highway where it doubles as an emergency air strip.

A good year fetches Malik Rs 5 lakh from his near-90 quintals of rice. But that source of sustenance for his family—wife, three daughters and a son—is literally crumbling to dust. "This is our traditional livelihood. We've no idea what to rely on in future," Malik says.

ON HIGH FLAME

Like him, thousands of paddy farmers across Kashmir are staring at devastation on their farmlands. A severe heatwave has dried up the canals that usually convey water to the fields from the glacier-fed rivers and streams that crisscross the Valley. Scorching temperatures in June and July, breaching 70- and 50-year-old records this year, have made for a prolonged dry spell, the likes of which, some farmers say, have not been seen in living memory.

Kashmir is running a near-100 per cent rainfall deficit in early July; a preliminary count aggregates almost 75 per cent shortfall in the second half of June. Southern Kashmir, especially Anantnag and Kulgam, is withering away as the Jhelum system runs on empty. This riverine lattice-work, encompassing the Vaishaw, Brengi, Sandran and Lidder rivers, is witnessing a five-year low, with the gauge at the key Sangam confluence in Anantnag touching minus 0.11 feet on July 5.

This has rendered irrigation facilities ineffective, with 19 lift schemes lying completely defunct and 41 partially working among the total 1,001 schemes